

Embodied AI: The Physical World Meets Intelligence

The digital world is clean. It operates on discrete logic, perfect memory, and predictable rules. The physical world is messy, chaotic, and governed by friction and gravity. For decades, AI has excelled in the former and struggled in the latter. But in late May 2026, Google DeepMind signaled that the wall between the digital and the physical is finally crumbling.

The Co-Scientist

The introduction of the **Co-Scientist** framework is a paradigm shift for research. It isn't just an LLM that reads papers; it is an agentic system that can formulate hypotheses, write the code to run a simulation, interpret the results, and iterate. More importantly, it is designed to interface with automated wet labs.

Imagine a chemistry lab where an AI proposes a novel compound, a robotic arm mixes the reagents, a mass spectrometer analyzes the result, and the AI immediately uses that data to adjust its next experiment. This closed-loop system accelerates the pace of discovery by orders of magnitude, turning months of manual labor into hours of automated synthesis.

Robotics-ER: Embodied Reasoning

Similarly, the **Gemini Robotics-ER 1.6** update brings advanced reasoning to physical robots. Previous robots relied on rigid, pre-programmed routines. ER 1.6 allows a robot to understand a high-level command ("clean up this spilled coffee") and dynamically reason through the physical steps required: locate a towel, understand the physics of wiping, and navigate around unexpected obstacles.

We are finally seeing the convergence of "mind" (the LLM) and "body" (the robotic actuator). This embodied intelligence is the prerequisite for AI to impact the physical economy—from manufacturing to elder care—in the way it has already impacted the digital one.

Contributor: Alessandro Linzi